Strategic Communication

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Strategic communication examines how organizations use communication purposefully to fulfill their mission. All types of organizations, including private and public sector organizations, political parties, NGOs, and social movements, use strategic communication to reach their goals. Centrally, strategic comunication examines the communicative practices of various types of organizations from an integrated perspective. It defines strategy as a multidimensional concept and understands communication as the constitutive activity of management.

Until recently, strategic communication was seen either as a rather vague term used across many different contexts, or, on the contrary, as a very precise term used in a specific context with a well-defined meaning. On the one hand, it was the synonym for all types of goal oriented communication, including for example marketing communications and public relations. On the other hand, it was the expression used by national and international institutions such as the US government and the United Nations for their use of communication to promote national and international interests and objectives.

However, from the mid-2000s onwards, the concept of strategic communication has become increasingly popular among practitioners as well as academics. Today, practitioners often use the term when they talk about their organizational function or practice. Similarly, academics use the term to identify a specific approach to the study of communicative practices of organizations, and include this phrase in the titles of institutions, publications, courses, and curricula.

A popular term

Every year since 2007, the European Public Relations Education and Research Association (EUPRERA) has conducted a large international survey in collaboration with, among others, the European Association of Communication Directors. Known as the European Communication Monitor (ECM), this survey includes responses from more than 2000 respondents from more than 40 European countries. In 2011, the survey included a set of questions related to which terms communication professionals would use if they were asked to refer to and describe their daily work: 67.9% of the respondents (in particular respondents from private companies) answered *corporate communication*; 61.3% (in particular respondents from nonprofit and governmental organizations) answered *strategic communication*; 46.7% said *public relations*; and 32.4% percent said *organizational communication* (Zerfass et al., 2011).

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The same year as the first ECM was conducted, the first issue of *International Journal of Strategic Communication* (IJSC) appeared. In the introductory article, titled "Defining Strategic Communication," the term is defined "in its broadest sense, (as) communicating purposefully to advance (the organization's) mission" (Hallahan et al., 2007, p. 4). In 2013, this definition was replaced by a more comprehensive definition in Holtzhausen and Zerfass's (2013) work: "Strategic communication is the practice of deliberate and purposive communication that a communication agent enacts in the public sphere on behalf of a communicative entity to reach set goals" (p. 74).

In addition to IJSC, a series of comprehensive publications, all with the terms *strategic* and *communication* in their titles, has been published. In 2014, Heath and Gregory edited a collection of key texts, *Strategic Communication I–IV*. In 2015, Holtzhausen and Zerfass edited *The Routledge Handbook of Strategic Communication*. Two further volumes, *International Encyclopedia of Strategic Communication I–III* (edited by Heath and Johansen) and *Managing Communications: A Strategic Approach* (by Zerfass, Frandsen, Nothaft, & Romenti) are scheduled for publication in 2017 and 2018, respectively.

The newly gained popularity of the concept of strategic communication among practitioners as well as academics can be explained in at least two ways. According to the first explanation, which is inspired by the sociology of the communication professions, strategic communication has become a popular term among practitioners because of its ability to replace already existing names in these professions, such as public relations, which have fallen into disfavor. Despite its efforts to change the reputation of the discipline, public relations still generates negative connotations, not least in a European context. From this perspective, practitioners favor strategic communication over public relations because the former fits better with the professional identity and self-perception of many communication professionals. Strategic communication has become a popular academic term because it possesses the necessary degree of interpretative viability, lending itself to various interpretations (Benders & van Veen, 2001). The concept is so general that different parties can each recognize their own version of it.

According to the second explanation, rooted in the contemporary history and/or sociology of communication studies, strategic communication is not just a term used in substitution for an ill-favored concept, but a new paradigm (Hallahan et al., 2007) or a distinct approach (Holtzhausen & Zerfass, 2015) that opens up new fields of interdisciplinary research. Behind this new paradigm or approach stands a small but diverse group of communication scholars (most of them originating from the discipline of public relations) from Europe and the United States.

Foundational assumptions

The discipline of strategic communication is based on five foundational assumptions. First, strategic communication is *the purposeful use of communication by an organization to fulfill its mission*. At the outset of the new discipline, it was emphasized by Hallahan and colleagues (2007) how important it is to be open to all conceptualizations of communication processes and effects. Thus, initially, both the transmission and the interaction model of communication together with the concept of meaning were

seen as relevant to the study of strategic communication. At the same time, however, communication was defined as the constitutive activity of management. Today, there is a much stronger focus on the constitutive model of communication, and on symbolic interactionism and postmodernism as the theoretical basis of this model.

Second, *all types of organizations* communicate to gain influence. There has been a tendency to see private companies as the only type of organizations that practice strategic management. However, public sector organizations, political parties, NGOs, and social movements are operating in an increasingly complex world and have the need to make strategic decisions and communicate strategically to attract attention, create a favorable reputation, and gain legitimacy among their key stakeholders.

Third, the communication activities of an organization can best be viewed *from an integrative perspective*. However, strategic communication differs from apparently similar approaches, such as integrated marketing communication (ICM), by its focus on communication activities across fields of practice. Hallahan (2004) identified six conceptual approaches to organizational communication commonly found in organizations: (1) management communication; (2) marketing communication; (3) public relations; (4) technical communication; (5) political communication; and (6) information/social marketing campaigns. These approaches differ from each other when it comes to personnel and tactics, but they share common goals and strategies. Strategic communication looks beyond disciplinary differences searching for commonalities and integration.

Fourth, and according to Holtzhausen and Zerfass (2015), there are five basic issues that most communication disciplines must address: (1) the identification and segmentation of stakeholders; (2) the selection of media channels; (3) the behavioral outcomes; (4) reputation management; and (5) the agency of communication professionals. In this understanding of strategic communication, a key role is ascribed to the *public sphere*, redefined as a communicative sphere which has become participative rather than representative (Bentele & Nothhaft, 2010). Consequently, the external dimension of strategic communication (e.g., maintaining a favorable reputation) is seen as more important than the internal dimension.

Fifth, the concept of *strategy* is the cornerstone of strategic communication. Strategy is used as an inclusive descriptor of organizational communicative practices. Underneath this understanding lies an ambition to rehabilitate the concept of strategy: to transform it from something which is perceived as negative and reductive into something which is perceived as more positive and comprehensive.

As a result of this ambition, strategic communication does not apply a mainstream modernist approach to strategic management – that is, a top-down approach based on the idea that the world can be controlled and that the strategy process can be viewed as rational decision making. From this perspective, communication is reduced to the transfer of information from top management to employees in organizational settings which are free of culture and conflict. Instead, strategy is viewed as a multidimensional concept that offers many alternative understandings including a postmodernist or critical approach.

Much attention is devoted to the concept of *emergence* which represents a more realistic and pragmatic perspective on strategy. The modernist ideas of control and

centrality in the strategy formulation and implementation process are dispelled and replaced by a postmodernist appproach according to which the strategy process will always be based on prior experience and actions and will always be dependent on the participation of many people.

Understanding strategy

Introducing strategic communication as a new paradigm or a distinct approach (Holtzhausen & Zerfass, 2013) is highly ambitious. However, there is one point where strategic communication has already made an important contribution to the communication discipline, although in a more indirect way, and that is by putting strategy at the top of the research agenda of communication scholars. What do we mean by strategy when we talk about *strategic* communication?

The concept of strategy as such is not new to the communication discipline. It appears in many different contexts, including expressions such as *strategic public relations* (cf. Grunig's (2006) distinction between an interpretive, symbolic approach, and a behavioral, strategic management approach to public relations) and *strategic organizational communication* (cf. Conrad and Poole's (2011) two-level concept of strategic choice making). Nevertheless, the concept of strategy remains implicit and/or underconceptualized in most cases. One way to solve this problem is to translate insights from management and organization studies where the concept of strategy has been a research topic for more than five decades.

As mentioned above, the concept of strategy is a multidimensional concept that has been defined and applied, with more or less diverging meanings, within a series of different theoretical contexts. It is possible to build up an overview of some of these contexts by making a distinction between five important lines of development, which together depict a shift from normative idealism to critical realism within the field of management and organization studies (Frandsen & Johansen, 2010). The five lines of development are described next.

Prescriptive and emergent perspectives on strategy

According to the prescriptive perspective, a strategy is the result of a linear, rational-analytical process in which a distinction is made between a series of clearly separated sequences such as *situational analysis*, *decision making* (*strategy formulation*) *implementation*, and *evaluation*. The prescriptive perspective is based on the idea that it is possible to define the objective of a strategy in advance and to develop its main elements, before it is implemented. This perspective focuses on how a strategy should be formulated, and not on how it in fact does get made.

According to the emergent perspective, a strategy is seldom the result of such a linear, rational-analytical process. Strategies do not always develop as planned or expected, but tend to emerge in organizations over time as a result of new opportunities, organizational learning, or even accidental actions. Therefore, the proponents of the emergent perspective claim that it is not possible to define the final goal of a strategy in advance, or

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to develop its main elements before it is implemented. From an emergent perspective, it does not make sense to perceive decision making and implementation as two clearly separated sequences in the strategy formation process.

The prescriptive perspective has been the dominant way of understanding strategy in management and organization studies since the 1960s. This also applies to public relations and organizational communication. An example is the C-MACIE (Communication, Management Analysis, Choice, Implementation, and Evaluation) framework established by Moss and DeSanto (2011). This model of communication management consists of four stages: (1) communication management analysis (conducting various types of environment scanning and analysis); (2) communication management choice (making choice decisions); (3) communication management implementation (e.g., directing people, resources, budgets); and (4) communication management evaluation (measuring outputs and outcomes).

Towards a scientific understanding of strategy

Until the end of the 1960s and the beginning of the 1970s, strategic management was based on intuitive understanding, and not on scientific investigation, often with a reference to Fayol's (1916) distinction between five managerial functions: to plan, to organize, to coordinate, to command, and to control.

However, in 1973, Mintzberg formulated his famous question: *What do managers really do when they manage?* It was the first in a series of empirical studies of what managers do or are expected to do (their behavior and activities, their functions and responsibilities), how they do what they do, with whom they interact and communicate, and what else they are doing (the informal aspects of managerial work). In his study, Mintzberg (1973) identified ten basic management working roles, which he divided into three categories: (1) interpersonal roles (the manager as figurehead, leader and liaison); (2) informational roles (the manager as monitor, disseminator, and spokesperson); and (3) decisional roles (the manager as entrepreneur, disturbance handler, resource allocator, and negotiator).

Subsequently, other scholars have discussed not only the empirical results, but also the theoretical and methodological issues that are linked to the study of "what managers really do when they manage." The studies conducted by scholars in public relations and organizational communication have only to a very limited extent been inspired by this type of empirical management research.

Functionalist and critical approaches to strategy

A third line of development is the shift from a functionalist to a critical approach to strategic management. Inspired among others by critical theory (the Frankfurt School), social constructivism, feminist theory, poststructuralism and French theory (Foucault, Derrida), the critical approach questions the dominant management principles of organizing (such as efficiency, rationality, homogeneity, and masculinity), bringing new meanings to the concept of strategy.

Already in the mid-1980s, management scholars such as Paul Shrivastava claimed that strategic management was an ideology and that the discourse on strategy helped legitimize existing power structures and resource inequalities. Other critical scholars defined corporate strategy as a set of discourses and practices which transform managers and employees alike into subjects who secure their sense of purpose and reality by formulating, evaluating, and conducting strategy.

Since the beginning of the 1990s, critical management studies (CMS) has established itself as a subdiscipline adding a new and provocative dimension to the agenda of management studies. According to Alvesson and Deetz (2000), critical management research includes three tasks: (1) an *insight* task demonstrating a commitment to "the hermeneutic, interpretive and ethnographic goals of local understandings closely connected to and appreciative of the lives of real people in real situations"; (2) a *critique* task counteracting the "dominance of taken-for-granted goals, ideas, ideologies, and discourses which put their imprints on management and organization idea"; and (3) a *transformative redefinition* task demonstrating a commitment to the pragmatic aspects of a critical approach, "recognizing that insight and critique without support for social action leaves research detached and sterile" (p. 17).

A critical approach to strategic management in public relations and organizational communication is no longer a rare sight. In her book on public relations, L'Etang (2008) describes strategic management as a "Holy Grail for some PR academics and some PR practitioners," and as an "ideological practice, focused on domination and power" (pp. 29–30). In organizational communication, a critical approach as such has been part of the research agenda since the interpretive turn in the early 1980s, without necessarily focusing on strategy and strategic management.

Macro- and microlevel approaches to strategy

The fourth line of development is the move in the 2000s towards a microlevel approach to strategy or strategizing, introduced under the label of *strategy as practice* (Golsorkhi et al., 2010). This new community of scholars is inspired by the practice turn in the social sciences. Like Mintzberg they want to study what people actually do when working with strategy in organizations:

> Strategy as practice attempts a fundamental inversion of dominant conceptions of strategy. Whereas strategy has traditionally been seen as something an organization has – for example, a diversification strategy or an internationalization strategy – for strategy as practice researchers, strategy is something you do. (Jarzabkowski & Whittington, 2008, p. 101)

At the macrolevel approach to strategic management, a strategy is something that an organization *has*. That is, a strategy is the result of one-off decisions; a strategy is developed in specific places (e.g., the board room), at specific times (e.g., during strategy seminars), and by specific persons at the top of the organizational hierarchy (top management or the board of directors); and a strategy is always formulated before it is implemented. The strategy as practice researchers take a somewhat different, microlevel approach. To them, strategy is first of all *strategizing*, something people *do*, an activity embedded in a specific organizational context. The result is a new focus on

the complex micro-practices constituting the everyday activities of organizational life including strategy making. Viewed from this perspective, strategic management is not a disembodied and decontextualized activity, but an interactive and situated type of behavior in organizational settings.

The concept of *strategy communication* belongs to the strategy of practice research. Strategy communication is a complex and multimodal practice which cannot be reduced to a single text, but involve various text genres and media (e.g., strategic plans, corporate press releases, annual reports, PowerPoint presentions), which all communicate about the strategy of an organization. Thus, it is important not to confuse the concept of strategy communication with strategic communication.

Leader- and follower-oriented perspectives on strategy

The fifth line of development is the shift from a leader-oriented perspective to a follower-oriented perspective on strategy. In communication theoretical terms, this shift can be seen as concomitant with the development from a transmission model to an interaction model of communication. In the first of the two perspectives, leadership is located exclusively with the sender (i.e., the manager). In the second of the two perspectives, leadership is the result of a dynamic interaction process where both the sender and the receiver (the employees) are active participants and producers of leadership.

According to the leader-oriented perspective, strategy is the result of the transmission of a manager's strategic decisions to the employees. Traditionally, this perspective has focused on leader identity (the trait approach) or leader behavior (the behavioral approach), including the recent theories of transactional versus transformational leadership. The employees are seen as passive and empty recipients waiting to be stuffed with managerial communication. They do not play an active role in the strategy process. Therefore, it does not really matter who they are.

According to the follower-oriented perspective, strategy is understood as an outcome of the interaction between the manager and the employees. Between these two extremes we find an array of intermediate positions, such as the theories of followers as moderators of leadership impact (e.g., contingency theories), substitutes for or neutralizers of leadership, constructors of leadership (e.g., theory of the romance of leadership), and, finally, followers as leaders (e.g., the theories of shared, collective or distributed leadership).

The understanding of strategy within the communication discipline has developed over a period of more than 30 years. Strategic orientation was already prominent as a topic of discussion in the 1980s, but it remained within the scope of the prescriptive perspective, without being very explicit about this strategic orientation. Since that time, and especially since the year 2000, the understanding of strategy among communication scholars has become more sophisticated. Strategic communication is the first approach to make the link between strategy and communication so explicit that it enters the name of the field of study. The biggest challenge that strategic communication will have to face – if it wants to fulfill its ambition of becoming a new paradigm or approach *sui generis* – is to articulate this link in a more elaborate way.

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SEE ALSO: Communicative Constitution of Organizations; Communication Management; Decision Making Processes in Organizations; Goal Setting; Leadership in Organizations; Management; Strategic Planning

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Trim Size: 170mm x 244mm Scott wbieoc194.tex V1 - 05/27/2016 12:11 A.M. Page 9

Further reading

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